

Standing out: Jyoti from JSW Soorma Hockey Club received the Hero Player of the Tournament cheque.

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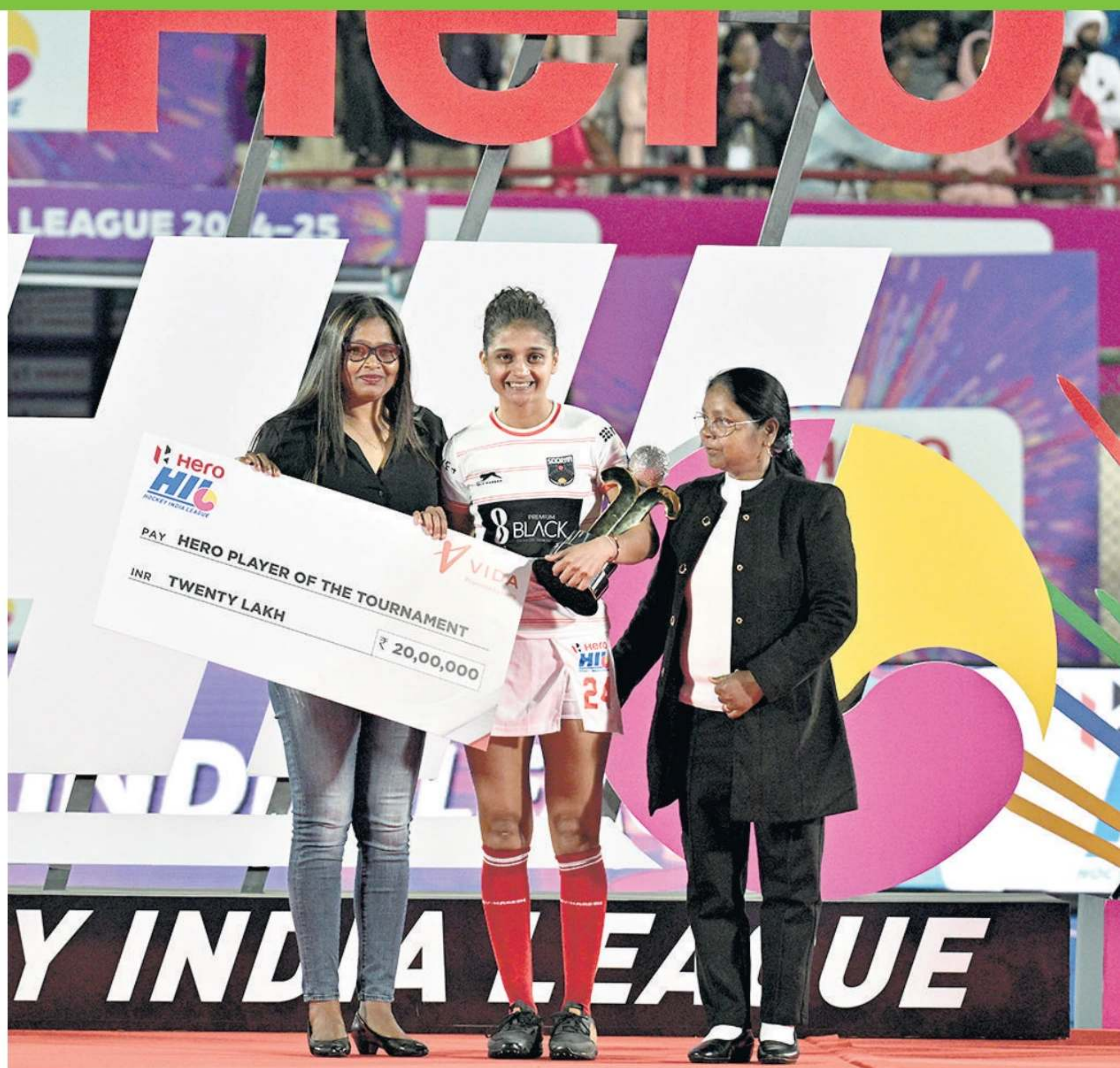
sponsored shoots and events, plus interactions with you guys (media), sometimes (laughs). Some of the foreign players were very pissed the other day," a Warriors player said off the record on the sidelines of the tournament.

JSW Soorma Hockey Club boss Jude Menezes remarked, "We travelled for two days to play one game in Rourkela. I understand the need to spread the game, but it remains a physical challenge. Travelling by bus took a lot out of our athletes. That's something I'd like to see changed."

When asked whether the HIL caravan needed to make more stops in different cities, India women's coach Harendra Singh said, "It's a huge ask. The broadcast team has to carry all its equipment. The budgetary aspect also needs to be considered. And the franchises move too, of course. It depends on whether you're aiming for sustainable, longer models like the IPL or the ISL (Indian Super League) or just a 4-5 year plan. Personally, the longer HIL runs, the more it benefits Indian hockey."

The HIL has arrived at an opportune moment — right as the Indian women's team is undergoing a steady but gradual transition. After an unprecedented fourth-place finish in Tokyo, India failed to secure a ticket to the Paris Olympics. The team found its lost spirit again when it won the Women's Asian Champions Trophy in Rajgir, Bihar.

Now, this competition is expected to help Harendra and newly-appointed captain Salima Tete identify and work around a core group of athletes in the lead-up to the 2028 Games in Los Angeles. It is understood that the Soorma pair of Sonam (the upcoming player of the tournament) and Jyoti (player of the tournament), along with Warriors' Annu, are the three young players who have impressed the selection committee the most, with



discussions already underway.

Additionally, the recently concluded edition served as a dry run for the FIH Pro League, which kicks off on February 15, with India set to face Spain, Germany, England, and the mighty Netherlands in Bhubaneswar.

Later in June, it will take on China, Australia, Argentina, and Belgium. The Pro League will also serve as a

qualifier for the 2026 Hockey World Cup.

The HIL-W's success may end up setting an example for other emerging franchise leagues to follow. There is considerable buzz regarding a business conglomerate showing interest in establishing a team based in Ranchi. The veracity of this claim, however, is yet to be confirmed.



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